

Personal Experience:

Hello everyone, my name is Nidhish Kakkireni! My experience with the CBE can be described in one word: unexpected. It all started when my KAP 6th-grade math teacher saw me excel in the subject and learn concepts incredibly fast. This led my teacher to suggest me to take the Credit By Exam to skip 7th and 8th grade math and move to Algebra 1 in my 7th grade year. Now, this was my mindset during that time. I had just moved to the US from my home country and was unfamiliar with the Katy ISD and US education systems. Hence, because it was a teacher recommendation, I attempted the 8th-grade Math CBE (you'll see why in a second), and I PASSED. Now, it wasn't a piece of cake because I knew nothing about the CBE and had nobody to assist me with it.

I will take you guys on a deep dive into CBE, so you know every single, micro-specific detail about this examination.

Lessons from my Experience:

- Skipping the 8th grade CBE contained far more rigour compared to the 6th grade CBE that most of my future friends took.
- This is because you are technically skipping 2 grade levels instead of one. Hence, it is highly recommended to take the 6th-grade CBE instead.
- Adding on to the previous point, taking the 6th-grade CBE might be a greater challenge than the 8th-grade one. This is because there is typically a big jump

in rigour compared to middle school and elementary math. That is also why many people who pass the CBE score extremely high if they skip the 8th grade compared to the 6th grade.

- Hence, it is your pick. If you are very adaptive to different forms of material, **GO WITH THE 6TH GRADE CBE.** * If you aren't so adaptive and are a very fast learner, go with the 8th-grade one.
- **Impact on future grades:** Every middle school math course contains some extremely fundamental concepts that are crucial for future maths. Hence, you also need to consider if you will be able to carry on the concepts that you have self-learned to the next level without teacher assistance. (but that shouldn't be the main reason to stop you from taking the CBE, because most of my future teachers were very flexible in explaining material).

Commonly confused terms:

- **Course:** This is a specific class (Algebra 2, Tennis, Health Science). This term is typically used in High school, as there are many courses available in each subject.
- **Subject:** This is a branch of knowledge that contains common characteristics of learning, understanding, and practicing. (Math, science, sports).
- **Endorsement:** Keep in mind that this is not an endorsement. An endorsement is a specific pathway in college or high school that requires completing certain courses.

For example, Algebra 2 would be a course within the subject of math. This course can be part of the Math endorsement taken within high school.

What is the CBE?

The Credit by Examination is a test that one can take to skip a Course, subject, or an entire grade level. This examination is typically taken to accelerate in subjects by earning more high school credits in advance, and providing a GPA boost. (Example below). As per my experience, the most common CBE that people take in junior high is for math (More on this later)

Scenario: person currently in the end of 5th grade

WITH CBE: – They will be taking the 6th-grade CBE	Without CBE:
6th Grade Course: 8th MATH KAP	6th Grade Course: 6th MATH KAP (includes ½ of 7th grade math)
7th Grade Course: Algebra 1: (no KAP course available for Algebra 1)	7th Grade Course: 8th Grade KAP
8th Grade Course: Geometry KAP	8th Grade Course: Algebra 1

According to the scenario, if a person takes the CBE, they will be ahead of a person without the CBE, as they will obtain 2 high school credits for math in Junior High

instead of 1. This, in the future, will enable a person taking the CBE to have a greater GPA and more open spots for their courses in high school.

Basing things to know before we divide into sections:

- To successfully skip the item, you must receive an 80% or higher. (more on this later).
- There is a \$75 Fee for each test.
- **IF YOU ARE TAKING THE CBE OF A HIGH SCHOOL COURSE, YOU ARE ONLY TAKING THE 4.0/ACA VERSION OF THAT COURSE**
- For Katy ISD, these exams are conducted by the universities UT, Texas Tech, or Avant.
- Katy ISD offers 4 time slots to take your exam – DOESN'T APPLY TO ELEMENTARY SCHOOLERS (based on the 2025-26 calendar, dates are typically in this range):
 - November(end)
 - February(mid)
 - June
 - July
- One person is limited to skipping only one grade level, or one course per subject per year
 - *For example*, if person A is in kindergarten, they are thinking of skipping 1st grade by taking the CBE over the February time slot. After he took the test, person A passed the exam. Person A also wants to skip 2nd grade

within the July slot. Person A CANNOT DO THIS as each person can only skip a MAXIMUM OF 1 GRADE LEVEL PER YEAR!!!

- *Another example.* Person B is currently an 8th grader. He took the Algebra 1 CBE in February and passed. Now, PERSON BE CANNOT SKIP ANOTHER MATH COURSE!!! IN THE SAME YEAR. HOWEVER, he is allowed to skip a course in another subject(Ex, Spanish).
- **The retake rule:** If one received a score of 80 or lower on any exam, they are allowed to take ONE retest for that course.
 - **THERE ARE SOME EXCEMPTIONS!!!:**
 - If one takes their CBE examination in June, a retest is only accepted if they get a 78 or a 79. Hence, if you score anything lower, you will not be able to retake the CBE for that course in the same year.
 - If one takes their CBE in July, you are simply not allowed to retake the test at all because there are no available slots for taking a test afterwards.

Skipping a Grade Level

This is only applied to ELEMENTARY SCHOOL GRADERS ONLY(K-5)

- You MUST score an 80% or higher on the Math, Science, Language Arts, AND Social Studies to skip the grade level.
- THERE IS ONLY ONE WINDOW TO TEST(TIME PERIOD)
- NO RETEST

- For Kindergarten, First Grade, and Second Grade assessments – Test question transcription by a proctor is allowed.

Skipping A Course – Junior High level – KAP Math

MATH STEPS:

1. 6th-grade Math
2. Seventh-grade Math
3. 8th-grade Math
4. Algebra I
5. Geometry
6. Algebra 2

Before jumping right in, you need to understand how KAP Math works:

- **6th-grade KAP** – A student in this class learns all of 6th-grade math and half of 7th-grade math, which is added to their syllabus.
- **7th-grade KAP** – The second half of 7th grade math left off from 6th grade, and COMPLETE 8TH GRADE MATH
- **8th grade KAP** – HIGH SCHOOL COURSE – Algebra I

How CBE applies to this arrangement:

Scenario 1: Taking the 6th-grade Math CBE in 5th grade(or in the summer after 5th grade ends).

If taking the 6th-grade math CBE(in 5th grade): You will be questioned on the 6th-grade ACA level of math.

KEEP IN MIND: Once you enter 6th grader you have two options:

- Taking the 7th-grade Math KAP class(recommended)
 - If so, you need to keep in mind that half of seventh-grade math is already taught in the previous year(6th-grade math, which you just skipped).
 - You will be learning 8th-grade math along with the second half of 7th-grade math.
 - You will take the 8th-grade math STAAR test.
 - When you are an 8th grader, you will be taking Geometry I KAP(if you passed). There is NO STAAR FOR GEOMETRY I KAP!!.
 - So, you will be taking the 8th-grade math STAAR - AGAIN!! - nothing to worry about, but just a mention.
- Taking the 7th grade Math ACA class(NOT RECOMMENDED):
 - You will simply take the 7th-grade math ACA curriculum
 - You will take the 7th-grade math STAAR test.

Scenario 2: Taking the CBE in 6th grade(or summer after) AND you did 6th Grade KAP math.

Two options: * If you want to continue the KAP math, you will take the 8th-grade math CBE: * Why? Because half of 7th-grade math and full 8th-grade math will be taught the year after. So, you must skip the 8th-grade math portion. * So the next year, when you are in 7th grade, YOU WILL BE TAKING ALGEBRA 1.

- You want to skip 7th grade Math – NOT AT ALL RECOMMENDED!!!!!!!
 - Why? You will be forcing yourself to take Academic 8th-grade Math in 7th grade, with no difference in just doing regular KAP math
 - Hence, even if you do the 7th-grade Math CBE or do KAP Math throughout middle school is the same.

Scenario 3: You are in 6th-grade ACA and trying to take the CBE:

Two options: * Taking the 7th grade Math CBE – NOT RECOMMENDED – This option might not be allowed – you should check with your counselor.

- Taking the summer course for converting to KAP math – recommended

Scenario 4: You are in 7th grade and trying to take the Algebra 1 CBE

CAUTION: This exam will be divided into two parts; you must get a 80% or higher on both parts to pass the CBE. IF YOU GET LOWER THAN A 90%, YOU WILL NOT HAVE A 4.0 GPA FOR THIS CLASS!! IT WILL BE A 3.0

Scenario 5: You are in 8th grade, going into 9th grade, and trying to take the Geometry CBE.

Assumption: You are in KAP Math and want to continue this path. – This is highly not recommended because when a person skips a high school credit course, such as

geometry in this case, they are skipping the academic version of the course. Hence, instead of receiving a maximum of 5.0 weighted GPA for geometry, you would only receive a maximum of 4.0 weighted GPA points. Although this seems very little, it might decrease your rank significantly (depending on the competitiveness of your school).

CBE for High School:

Math:

If you are willing to continue the KAP path, **IT IS NOT RECOMMENDED TO DO ANY CBE OTHER THAN ALGEBRA 1:** Why? Because excluding Algebra 1, every other Math High school class that you can take the CBE in is a KAP or an AP class. Hence, they are 5.0s instead of Algebra 1's 4.0 (there is no KAP Algebra 1). When you are taking any CBE for a high school class, YOU ARE ALWAYS TAKING THE ACA VERSION. Hence, if you take, for instance, the Geometry CBE, you will be skipping the ACA version, so if you pass, the maximum GPA you can get is a 4.0, in contrast to the in-school KAP geometry course, which maxes out at a 5.0

Foreign Languages:

As for my experience, this is another common CBE that many people take after Math. It is very good if you want to get a head start with credits, and it enables you to obtain all of your mandatory language courses for High school.

How it works/what is different: If you want to skip two years of language at once:

- You must take the level 1 and level 2 examinations first. (Yes, I know it is a lot)
- This is very recommended if you already speak, write, and/or read the language that corresponds to the CBE you are about to take.
- If you don't speak, write, and/or read the language you want to take the CBE, you might have to prepare more, as you will be exposed to a language that you aren't fluent in. However, as per my experience, there have still been some people who have taken the CBE for a language that they aren't fluent in.

Scenario #1:

One can also skip level 3 of the given foreign language. However, THIS IS NOT RECOMMENDED because again, you are going to be skipping the ACADEMIC level of the course. Hence, you will miss out on the KAP level course that is offered at your Katy ISD school. This is because all level 3 languages are KAP level courses, meaning that they are weighted on a 5.0 scale instead of a 4.0 scale (which corresponds to the CBE).

We will be focusing more on specific courses because there are fewer elementary schoolers.

Other Subjects:

On the Katy ISD page about the CBE (this is the place where I received most of my information from), it states that you can take the CBE for a course in other subjects like Science or Social Studies. However, as per my experience, I have never heard a single person taking the CBE for a subject other than Math or a Foreign language.

Here is why: For almost all Science and Social studies courses, a KAP/AP level course is available. Hence, instead of taking a 5.0 weighted course, you will skip a 4.0, ACA-level course. This can decrease your GPA if you have more than 5.0 courses in your transcript. Hence, if you do want to skip or accelerate in those courses, I would recommend that you wait until High School for you to take them as summer courses.

Study Resources:

My experience:

Because I took the 8th-grade math CBE, I had to learn half of 7th-grade math and all of 8th-grade math at once. I have listed the main resources I have used below:

- **Khan Academy:** This is an excellent resource that contains several courses that align with Texas TEKS. If you finish the corresponding course and all of the practice problems given, you are already 80% ready.
 - Some people typically complete the get-ready courses first. Although this might be a good option for some, it doesn't cover all the concepts, and you will miss out on some key points. Hence, you should start a course that matches your CBE and contains the Texas TEKS specification.
 - KHAN ACADEMY IS 100% FREE!!
- **STAAR Released Tests:** Although this might seem unconventional at first, as per my experience, the CBE(for math) is very similar to that year's STAAR test. Hence, because TEA releases previous year assessments, it is a great resource for you to practice and test your knowledge.

- **PRACTICE:** This might seem obvious, but for any CBE (especially for a math course), practice is crucial for you to test your knowledge. You should try to take some mock tests, see which areas you are weak in, and practice more in those areas. (I will list more tools to get practice questions below.) Lastly, because you didn't actually take that course in school, you are not likely habituated to the material. Hence, doing practice questions is the best way to ace this test.
- **UT study guides:** Study guides are posted on the Katy ISD website on the CBE (links below). The study guides contain:
 - A list of every unit and concept you need to know – this enables you to track your progress.
 - Practice problems/similar questions

*** All the resources mentioned above are free for use.

Other resources/links:

- **Notebook LM:** You can paste the UT study guides into this AI tool and generate more practice problems that are similar to the sample questions given. requires a paid subscription if you want to use a very high amount of resources. (not needed, unless you don't have any tokens left to prompt it)
 - Also great for creating more study material like flashcards, podcasts, videos, etc.
 - Link: <https://notebooklm.google/>
- **STAAR released tests:** <https://tea.texas.gov/data-reports/staar/staar-released-test-questions>
- **Khan Academy:** <https://www.khanacademy.org/>

- **All CBE course offerings**(Some may not apply to your school; please check with your counselor if you can apply for this CBE first.):

https://resources.finalsite.net/images/v1745887403/katyisdorg/q6nnngd3nhe0pg47lozc/courses_offered.pdf

- **All study guides:** Found in the source link below.

Source:

<https://www.katyisd.org/research-assessment-and-accountability/national-and-local-assessment/credit-by-examination-cbe>